compensated for this by using Hezbollah in South Lebanon as its long arm to advance its strategic objectives. Thus a meeting of interests between Iran, Syria, and Hezbollah was formed. Syria's main role in this coalition has been to serve as a transit state for all Iranian weapons transferred to southern Lebanon, as a storage depot for some of these weapons, and as a refuge and activity base for the top echelons of Hezbollah. Syria's use of Hezbollah has allowed the Syrians deniability with regard to their direct involvement in terrorism, though Syria is considered a terrorist state (which was involved, among other things, in the assassination of Lebanese prime minister Rafik Hariri and has housed the headquarters of Islamic Jihad and Hamas).

In the wake of the First Lebanon War and the IDF's withdrawal from Lebanon in 2001, a balance of terror between Israel and Hezbollah quickly developed. How was this disconcerting situation created?

In 1999, Syria was forced to withdraw its military forces from Lebanon, but it maintained its close ties with Hezbollah and adopted the organization as its long arm against Israel. Iran also adopted Hezbollah as part of its strategy to become a regional power and as part of its deterrence doctrine. Iran sought to build up a threat on the Israeli border that could be used against Israel in the event of an American attack against Iran, as well as in the case of a possible Israeli attack. Israel evacuated its forces from Lebanon in 2001, declaring, as mentioned, that any provocation by Hezbollah would elicit a severe Israeli response. Unfortunately, Israel did not implement this policy. Hezbollah, for its part, occasionally tested Israel's declared policy and realized that Israel was not standing behind it.

What were the reasons for Israel's failure to follow through on its threats?

There is no simple answer to this question; rather, a series of factors must be taken into account. First, Prime Minister Ehud Barak, who pulled the IDF out of Lebanon and was the person who issued the ultimatum to Hezbollah, wanted to be free to pursue diplomatic activity. He initially gave priority to the negotiations with the Syrians over talks with the Palestinians and wanted a quiet border in the north. This quickly became irrelevant. When the Assad-Clinton meeting in Geneva failed, Barak gave up on the negotiations with Syria and turned his focus toward the withdrawal from Lebanon. Not long afterwards, the Second Intifada broke out, a challenge that quickly became the first priority, not by choice, but out of necessity. An